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Shown the Score, Still No-Show

An Eight-Week Trial of a Community Tennis-Court Booking App’s Live Slot-Reliability Score

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Background

Booking apps for shared community facilities increasingly surface a live reliability score to anyone waiting on a full slot. Whether seeing that number changes who actually turns up — or only reshuffles who claims the gap it leaves — has not been tested.

What we set out to test

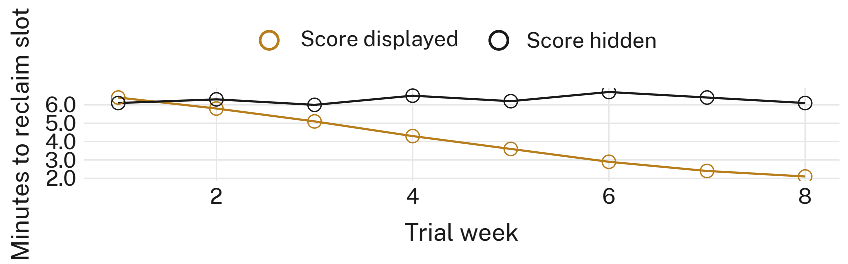
- Test whether a live Slot-Reliability Score changes a court’s own no-show rate
- Track whether display shifts who claims a slot once it frees up
- Compare display courts against score-blind courts over identical weeks

Methods

- 14 public courts · 6 councils · 7 score-displayed, 7 score-hidden · 8 weeks
- Reliability score computed by the booking platform’s existing attendance model, held identical across arms
- Court-side observer logs of queue hand-offs, cross-checked against the app’s own booking-close timestamps

Findings

No detectable difference in no-show rate emerged between score-displayed and score-hidden courts. Median time to reclaim a freed slot at displayed courts fell by two-thirds over the trial; hidden-score courts showed no equivalent change.



Median time to reclaim a freed slot fell from 6.4 to 2.1 minutes over the trial at score-displayed courts (n = 7); hidden-score courts held steady at 6.1–6.7 minutes.

Discussion

The score changed nothing about who shows up — only how fast the gap left behind gets filled, recruiting the queue as the mechanism it already claims to provide. Where next: a longer deployment testing whether faster hand-offs erode the informal courtesies that currently manage a freed court without one.

Selected references

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Court-side observation logged behaviour only; no player names or booking histories were retained.

“The queue got faster. The no-shows didn’t.”

8-week trial, 14 public courts: no-show rate unchanged, median slot-reclaim time down two-thirds where the score was shown.

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